Over Email (She's a Bitch)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36929185.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationship:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	alternative universe – office, Modern AU but still Canon Species, Humor, Getting Together, idiots to lovers, Trans Adora (She-Ra), You've heard of Meet Cute, Now get ready for Meet Angry, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting
Language:	English
Collections:	Catradora AUs by n7punk
Stats:	Published: 2022-02-06 Words: 11,470 Chapters: 3/3

Over Email (She's a Bitch)

by n7punk

Summary

Adora isn’t the kind of person to be rude to strangers, but in her defense, she is having a rough week at work and Accounting started it. They can only exchange so many passive-aggressive emails before somebody was going to confront the other face-to-face, but when it happens, Adora is stunned to discover that she actually knows the faceless accountant she has been fighting with.
(Or, Social Media Manager Adora/Accountant Catra office AU)

Adora

Chapter Notes

> This AU is set in a world where the subject line of every email you send doesn't dox you with your full name. The internal company email system just says the department name in front of emails instead. I realize this isn't how it works but shush. You can click on the email address to see someone's profile and name instead.
> "Slack" is an inter-organization messaging software if you haven't encountered it before/don't use it where you are.
> This is also purely a Get Together fic. There's not much after that. Honestly this isn't up to my usual personal standards, but I wrote and edited it, so I thought I would post it anyway. I didn't want to waste the effort I already put in even if I don't have the energy to fix it up. It's got some funny moments I would hate to lose, so it's here if y'all want it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora normally tries to be a nice person. She's polite to service workers, she always tips, she smiles at strangers, and she always lets one person in ahead of her car in traffic. Everybody has off days, though, and she is having a hell *week*. Her car got hit while parked on the street, she is pseudo-PMSing, and she got promoted at work, which would be a good thing if she were actually qualified, but she was promoted mostly based on being the only other full-time Social Media employee at the time when her boss quit.

Adora needs to either get a punching bag to herself for a good two hours or to snap at *somebody*. Neither of those are options though, so she just lets it build up until she gets a snarky email from Accounting that not so subtly implies they don't know how she got this far without knowing how spreadsheets work. Adora *does* know how they work, thank you very much, but it's her first fucking week in this position and her predecessor bailed without teaching her shit. She isn't going to magically know all the information that Accounting needs or their standard format.

Maybe it is because the accountant just signed off by their last name and it's easier to forget that *D'Ream*, whoever they are, is a real person. Maybe Adora is just at the end of her rope and it would have happened anyway to the next person who gives her a hard time. Adora writes back an email asking how anyone smart enough to get an accounting certification doesn't realize that people need to learn things and can't magically predict what a stranger wants them to do. From that moment, it is on.

Adora maybe should have avoided pissing someone off during her first week as the lead of the Social Media team – which right now, isn't much of a team – but in her defense, Accounting shouldn't be so fucking rude. Adora only refers to it as "Accounting" in her head as if the entire department is a single, nebulous entity that she is in a feud with. It makes it easier to not feel guilty as they fire emails back and forth.

“This isn’t like you,” Glimmer observes as they eat lunch together. They are in the second-floor breakroom, but Adora just got an email ping from her phone and she isn’t letting Accounting feel smug about her being unable to reply on her lunch break. Adora glances up from typing out her response to look at Glimmer. She seems semi-delighted by this turn of events. She is a closeted bitch though and she is probably living vicariously through Adora right now. Adora knows that she has wanted to send some passive-aggressive emails herself before. Bow looks *concerned*.

“They’re the ones who declared war. I’m just finishing it,” Adora responds as she types out an extremely sarcastic response asking the accountant to walk her through every standardization code she needs her spreadsheet to conform to in order for their system to automatically pull data from it. Adora was going off of an old spreadsheet of intern data that she found, but apparently it is wildly out of date. Supposedly there is a manual that she could have used as reference, but as far as she can tell, this particular accountant is the only person who knows that it exists.

Adora certainly wasn’t given it along with her new job title. She could message her manager in the Marketing department asking how to properly format her spreadsheets, and maybe she would on the average day, but at this point she is intent on making it Accounting’s problem. She will submit her next spreadsheet properly formatted, but she is going to make them waste their time explaining every cell on it to her first.

“Adora, I really think you need a break,” Bow tries to reason. Adora looks up from her phone only long enough to send him a look of disdain before she returns to typing her passive-aggressive and somewhat condescending message. Normally this isn’t her thing, but she used to be best friends with a master of dismissal and she isn’t above using the things that she learned from her. She nearly makes a comment in the email about how she is just a dumb blonde and needs people to explain things slowly to her, but she doesn’t want the conversation to take a turn.

Sure, they have exchanged some strong words disguised in the passive-aggressiveness of office-speak, but she doesn’t need to accuse a person who has never met her of discriminating her based on stereotypes or sexism. She doesn’t have a photo on her company profile, so the most they have is her name, and that’s only if they clicked on her email address. Adora has purposefully been avoiding doing that for *c.dream* so it’s easier for her to be rude to them – although it is getting easier with every email regardless.

“No, no, let her keep going. I want to see what happens,” Glimmer tells Bow. Adora snorts, sending Glimmer a look that tells her what she thinks of that vote of confidence, but she doesn’t protest out loud. She could use someone in her corner, even if their motivation is for all the wrong reasons. Adora is hoping to come into work on Monday feeling a bit refreshed and ready to take on a new week without sending anyone bitchy emails, but if Accounting still has a rat crawled up their ass, Adora isn’t going to let herself be walked on just because she’s the rookie.

Know your worth, her adoptive mom tells her. Adora has some issues with that. She doesn’t think that Mara intends for her to use that advice to justify sending angry emails, but what she doesn’t know won’t hurt her. Adora hits send before Bow can try to talk her out of it

again. If this leads to an awkward meeting at the annual company party one day, sobeit. Adora is prepared to face the consequences of her actions.

Email sent, she finally puts down her phone and returns to her lunch. It will take awhile for them to answer all of her questions, and if they miss any then Adora will get to make a snarky comment about them having trouble reading. It's a win-win.

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Somehow, Adora's snarky emails turn into a feud that all of Marketing and her friends within the company watch with fascination. The next version of the spreadsheet apparently shows up as all-errors whenever Accounting tries to access it and they send several emails back and forth, growing so passive-aggressive that they would make a southern grandmother proud, before accounting finally tells her that all her formulas are referencing the old version of the sheet.

Adora knows how to use Excel, alright, but things like data paths are a little beyond her. The data was all there for *her* because the data source referred to the exact path where she had the original version of the sheet stored on her computer, but those cells became blank when someone without the other sheet tried to download it. Adora got a dozen emails in before she realized that she had actually fucked up the sheet when she copied formulas from her old spreadsheet.

Her intern laughs at her face when she reads the latest email from Accounting and realizes. Adora threatens to fire Frosta, but everybody knows that she won't do it. Frosta flips her off in response. That's just what the Marketing department is like. They don't really give a shit about the company, just doing well enough that no one outside of the department comes to check in on them. It's especially true in the Social Media team. Adora is the boss and even she doesn't give a shit.

She is invested in her battle with Accounting, though. The next version of the spreadsheet is apparently still in violation of three of the codices that Adora still hasn't *seen*, but they are ones about information presentation and labeling standards and shouldn't affect Accounting's ability to balance her small budget. Adora is certain that they are only coming down on her for them because of the earlier snippiness. She doesn't back down. She fixes the issues, of course, but she is sarcastic about their inability to understand such obvious data when she sends off the fix to them.

Accounting emails her back and asks her if Frosta really has done no work – according to payroll? No. Actually? Yes – because she didn't mark any funds to go to her internship subsidy. Adora is sure that they have to be fucking with her at this point, but when she checks the sheet, she finds the cell is actually blank. She fixes it and gets an email back within five minutes – she swears D'Ream is waiting for her emails at this point and that the entire Accounting department is watching their war just as avidly as the Marketing department is – informing her that she copied a formula linked to a different spreadsheet again.

“I swear, I’m *this* close to walking down there,” Adora declares as she shows Glimmer the email. Glimmer came over to her office because apparently there is a special Slack group for the observers of this battle that Adora isn’t a part of. It informed Glimmer there had been in a development so of course she dropped everything to come see despite the fact that the regular Marketing department tends to have actual work to do. Adora tried to get an invite to the group chat. Mermista didn’t even look at her in response.

“Wasn’t this one totally your fault?” Mermista drawls from where she is leaned back in one of Adora’s spare chairs, catching the Swedish fish that Sea Hawk is throwing into her mouth. He doesn’t even work here, he just showed up to pester Mermista. Adora closes her eyes and counts to five.

“Can’t you just go to the gym to punch the aggression out like you usually do and leave Accounting alone?” Bow asks. Adora narrows her eyes at him. He *never* suggests that she falls back on punching away her feelings and that isn’t going to magically stop Accounting from being dicks. She is way too far in to start backing down now. Accounting will assume that they won. Sure, they have been right at several points throughout this process, but they also clearly have it out for her.

“Remember the Phi Phi Phi feud?” Adora asks. Bow puts his head in his hands. Adora was in a sorority in college pretty much exclusively because both her moms were in it – albeit years apart – and met each other at an event for it. Adora actually liked it – it wasn’t the stereotypical sorority you tend to see in movies – but at one point they got in a fight with their neighboring sorority house that held loud parties and left trash littered everywhere. Eventually, one resulted in their neighbouring fence being broken just because they had the misfortune of being near drunks.

The other sorority had Phi in their name twice, they had Phi in *their* name in the one spot that the other sorority was missing it, and thus the entire school called it the Phi Phi Phi feud. It ended with disciplinary action to both sororities and an increased campus police presence around their houses, which coincidentally helped keep the parties down, but no one ever figured out that Adora was the one behind the Nair Conditioner Incident. It was her only overt contribution to the entire battle, but they deserved it for the move with the laxatives. No one suspected one of the background members was the one to make such a devastating strike.

“Do you want to get fired?” Bow asks. Adora pauses to consider it and Bow whines. “Adora, *no*,” he chides. Adora doesn’t want to get fired, but she really doesn’t think she would be over these emails, especially not when Accounting gives as good as it gets. She isn’t backing down.

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Adora doublechecks the next version before sending it. She even downloads it on her phone to make sure that it displays right. She sends it off smugly, waiting for Accounting’s response and knowing that it is beyond reproach. An hour later, she finally gets an email back.

You misspelled marketing. Please resubmit.

Adora stands up from her desk and marches down to Accounting. She kind of wishes that they were in a high-rise so she would have longer to consider her choices, but Accounting is just down a single flight of stairs and a left turn down a hallway. Adora finds herself standing in front of a door labeled *Accounting* after only a minute has passed, which isn't enough time for her to change her mind. She opens the door to find four cubicles and a mass of filing cabinets lining the walls. She can't see if the two further ones are occupied, but she doesn't care. At least half of Accounting is here and they can pass on a message if nothing else.

"Alright, I don't know which one of you is *C. D'Ream* but I've had a *month* and I don't need you making it harder over something so petty. My boss put in her two weeks' notice when she was already gone on her vacation and I have had to teach myself everything without any training. Give me a copy of this supposed manual and cut me some slack," Adora rants to the room. The words have been building up ever since she walked into work one day and found that she was no longer a *temporary* substitute.

In the silence that follows her statement, Adora's actions begin to catch up with her as the close accountants crane around at their desks and blink at her with wide eyes. Oh, she is so getting in trouble. From one of the far cubicles, an annoyed sigh rings out. The other accountants don't look away from Adora as a magicat stands up, still facing their desk as they pull off each of their hybrid ear mufflers, but as they turn to face Adora, she feels her jaw fucking drop. There is absolutely no way.

"I- *Catra*?" Adora asks, because it can't be. Sure, it looks like her even after a decade, and there can't be that many heterochromic magicats here, but- it just *can't* be, and besides, Catra's last name was fucking Driluth. Shit, did she get *married*? Catra, for her part, stares at Adora with steadily widening eyes. The longer she looks at Adora, the wider her eyes get and the more it seems like she is *realizing*. Catra opens her mouth and Adora quickly cuts her off.

"Can I talk to you outside?" she blurts out, because it would be fucking awkward if Catra asks her if she is who she thinks she is in front of other people. All of Adora's earlier annoyance is gone. The feud with Accounting is vanished from her mind in favor of the looping thought of *what the fuck*. Catra nods, slow and wordless.

"Um, boss?" one of the other accountants questions from the side, but Catra just waves noncommittally at him without looking away from Adora, already walking forward.

"Get back to work," she orders, her voice distant as Adora hurries to open the door. Adora watches Catra walk past her into the hall with a surreal feeling hanging over her.

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Adora quickly leads Catra to the stairwell. It's the closest semi-private spot. As soon as the door closes behind them, Catra leans against the wall and crosses her arms. She eyes Adora

up almost suspiciously, like she doesn't believe what she is seeing. Adora can't help but hope that she is cataloguing the differences.

"It's Adora, now. Adora Grayskull," Adora blurts out before Catra can speak. She was afraid that Catra would say her old name in front of the other accountants. She wouldn't have said her birth one, but she probably would have used the new one that Adora was testing out when they were last together. She didn't end up picking it. She took Mara's suggestion instead. Across from her, Catra swallows, a muscle in the side of her neck flexing.

"You… look good," Catra tells her, her voice still sounding a little distant as she sweeps her eyes over Adora again. Adora was shocked to see her, but the realization was definitely slower for Catra. After all, the last time they saw each other Adora hadn't started hormones. She looks different, she *sounds* different, and she has an entirely different name. Adora saw Catra and she just knew, different last name aside. She hasn't changed all that much.

"I, um, got stuff done after I was adopted," Adora explains, gesturing to herself, even though she is sure that Catra knows who she is by now. Catra's eyes stick on Adora's chest for a moment and Adora realizes that she did kind of gesture right to it when she said that. While that was certainly part of *stuff*, she doesn't think it makes her less recognizable and she sincerely didn't mean it like that. When Catra meets her eyes, both of them are blushing.

"Good. Had to use that time you weren't learning Excel on improving something," Catra says. Adora, who has felt breathless since the moment that Catra turned around, feels the bubble of weirdness this extended moment has been encased in pop at that moment. She huffs out a laugh, relaxing a little as she shoves her hands in her pockets and lets her shoulders fall, the physical tension gone. This is really happening. This is really Catra, who she has really been passive-aggressively emailing back and forth for weeks.

"Listen, I was having a hard week and I felt like I couldn't back down, and you were giving me a hard time, and it kind of all makes sense now that I know it was you," Adora says, a bit breathlessly. She feels like she is looking at Catra too much, or maybe she is just being awkward in general, but she can't stop sweeping her eyes over her. It has been a decade since they were last in the same room together. The foster home they grew up in got shut down in high school after an investigation into their practices. They were older kids, difficult to place, and they both went separate ways in the system. Adora didn't think that she would ever see her best friend again.

"I- Catra, you- How have you been?" Adora stammers out, incoherent but desperately needing to know. How do you go about catching up on ten years? Especially at *work*? Catra pauses. Adora feels like she is holding her breath, hoping for anything other than *I'm fine* or *I've been good*. She doesn't want a bland, meaningless answer. She wants to know where Catra picked up the name D'Ream, how she ended up as an accountant, and if she's married. She wants to know if she was also having a bad day when she sent the first email or if she just always emails like that, because Adora could see it going either way.

Before Catra can give her any of those answers, though, the exterior door on the first floor of the stairwell opens. Adora can see light over the railing. Both she and Catra send awkward looks to each other as they are forced to listen to what sounds like three people argue. It isn't clear about what, but they can't seem to agree on what happened in a story that they're telling

each other. Catra wrinkles her nose and Adora shuffles to the side of the staircase to let them pass as they make their way up a little. As they walk past, Adora catches the scent of cigarettes and realizes why Catra's face twitched like that.

The three men keep climbing until the fourth floor, where they let the door swing shut with a resounding thud. Adora immediately looks at Catra hopefully. She has had plenty of time to come up with an answer. Catra, in the middle of eyeing Adora up and down again, looks away quickly. Her tail is sweeping back and forth, pausing a little at the end of each wide sweep. Adora used to know Catra's body language intimately and she hopes that is still true, but the only times that she remembers her tail moving quite like that were when she was curled up somewhere warm or getting her ears scratched, so Adora doesn't know what that means in this context.

"I can't be away from the office too long or my team is going to think you snapped and murdered me. Short version is that I got into a better foster family and they supported me through school. I ended up here right after I got my certificate," Catra tells her.

"I don't want the short version," Adora says immediately, not hesitating long enough to think. Both of Catra's eyebrows shoot up and Adora ducks her head somewhat apologetically. She should be less eager. If Catra was fostered rather than adopted, then her last name probably changed when she was married. Adora shouldn't be jumping all over her like she is still a lovestruck teenager and they last saw each other yesterday. She is definitely still lovestruck, but the rest of those things aren't true anymore.

"After work. We're busy even if someone wasn't going to come looking for me," Catra tells her. Adora is a little disappointed – she kind of doesn't want to let Catra out of her sight – but the idea of *after work* is exciting. They can take as long as they want then – provided Catra's wife doesn't get mind her staying out – and they can talk more freely than they would in the office stairwell.

"Right, okay, yes, sure. I'll, um, come down at five?" Adora says, unable to tamp down her eagerness to any sort of socially acceptable level. Catra snorts, shooting her an amused look, but her tail is still sweeping back and forth. It might just be because of the weird lighting in the stairwell, but her eyes look a little blown out too.

"I'll try to be done on time. And you don't need to resubmit the spreadsheet because of a spelling error," Catra tells her. Adora grins at her.

"I know. You were just being an ass," Adora says before she thinks better of it. They used to be able to say shit like that to each other, but it has been a long time since they were friends and they're at work. Luckily, Catra doesn't seem bothered. She smirks at Adora and shrugs.

"You deserved it. I'd still like to have words with whoever skipped basic procedure training with you," she returns. Adora really doesn't want to leave, but Catra shoves off the wall and uncrosses her arms in a clear signal for them to get back to work. Adora reluctantly reaches for the door and holds it open for her. Apparently some of her disappointment shows, because Catra rolls her eyes as she sweeps past Adora.

“A few hours won’t kill you, Eternia,” Catra says to her, the words rolling so naturally off her tongue that Catra doesn’t seem to realize she has used Adora’s old last name until she is already halfway through the door, her step faltering. Adora is already waving her off by the time that she looks over her shoulder apologetically.

“I don’t mind that. My friends know that I’m adopted. I’d rather you default to my old last name than… anything else,” Adora assures her. She went by her last name a lot growing up. She always liked the sound of it better than her birth name even before her egg cracked. It would be much easier to explain to someone else listening why Catra was using the wrong last name than why she accidentally used any of the first names that Adora tried. Her friends know she is trans, but she isn’t the kind of person to talk about it much. She would just rather be her without any of the rest mattering.

“Got it. I’ll try to… fix it in my head this afternoon,” Catra promises her as she disappears through the door. Adora gives her a soft, grateful smile in return, feeling her heartrate quicken. She can go back to her office now, but she is going to be unproductive all afternoon. She isn’t going to think about anything but Catra.

Chapter End Notes

Social Media (sub-department of Marketing): Adora (manager), Intern Frosta.
Marketing: Glimmer.
Graphics (sub-department of Marketing): Mermista.
Accounting: Catra, Kyle.
IT: Entrapta, Rogelio.
HR: Scorpia.
Sea Hawk is a radio host. Perfuma works across town and Bow works at another company in the same building complex. Oh and there are other employees in these departments, but the main cast isn’t friends with them.

Catra

Chapter Notes

> Catra is just going to call Adora by her name always because while it takes a little while to retrain a name, I'm not doing deadname shit. This is also a "no/low transphobia" AU, but Shadow Weaver was going to be controlling about every aspect of their lives that she could, so that extended to Adora's gender/transitioning and is why she did the medical part after getting adopted. This AU isn't meant to be particularly deep (lore-wise) or realistic, just a little bit of office fun.
> **CW**: That said, it's Catradora, so implied/referenced child abuse in the past.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora shows up in the Accounting office a few minutes after five like she is picking Catra up from her parents' house for a date. She hovers outside the door for a moment before knocking and offers everyone apologetic smiles like it will erase their memory of her from a few hours ago. This is Catra's team, though, so Adora's bitchiness really couldn't compare to what they put up with on a daily basis. Adora lights up when Catra acknowledges her, even though it is only to tell her to give her a few minutes.

Part of the reason that Catra was so snippy in her emails was that she was *busy* and she didn't need some rookie promoted above their paygrade making her job harder. The rest of the reason was because she's a bitch. Catra had work throughout the day, but she found time to google Adora and found her LinkedIn page. It really just gave her the very basics like where she went to school and her degree, but it felt good to look at. Catra maybe tabbed over to it to look at Adora smiling in her headshot a few times. She couldn't help it, she looks so *different*.

Catra had a strange moment when she first saw her in the office, but she wasn't even sure why. It wasn't until Adora said her name that it clicked, and even then, it took a few minutes to fully process. Adora's face shape has definitely softened up. Her body is different in a lot of ways too. Her eyes are the same though, as is that dumb ponytail. Even the looks that she gives Catra are the same, as if they last saw each other just yesterday.

Catra wasn't expecting to ever see Adora again, but when she imagined it… well, alright, when she imagined it Adora *did* still look at her that, but Catra didn't think it was realistic, she was just having a fantasy. Adora looks better than she imagined. She is beaming as she offers to drive them down the street to a casual restaurant. Catra accepts. Normally Catra and Scorpia carpool, so she doesn't actually have a car at work. She already texted Scorpia that she was getting dinner with a coworker and to head home without her.

"Tell me about what happened with you?" Adora asks, hopefully, after they have reached the restaurant and placed their orders. Catra hesitates. She doesn't like opening up. She would much rather Adora talk first so Catra can feel her out again after all this time, but she

supposes she could give a quick summary without having to get too into emotions. They are in public after all.

“I got placed with a foster family pretty quickly after the… whole thing,” Catra says. Adora nods quickly. They don’t need to rehash the abuse in their group home finally being discovered and all the kids getting scattered to the four winds. Their living situation was bad, but it was weirdly stable. They had been there ever since they were little. Their entire world changed and it took a long time for it to start feeling safer, especially after they were separated and without support. The only good thing was that Catra didn’t get bounced around much before they found her a long-term foster.

“They already had a daughter that I became friends with and we still live together. They’re not my family or anything, but… they are my *foster* family, you know?” Catra explains, saying more than she means to, but it’s hard to describe the form that *family* takes when you’ve spent your whole life in the system. Adora, however, gets it, nodding understandingly.

“They never adopted me, but I did end up changing my name to theirs when I was nineteen. It was my foster sister’s idea,” Catra adds, shrugging. That story is a lot longer and more complicated than she makes it sound – there was a lot of crying and *your moms wouldn’t want me to* involved before Scorpia took matters into her own hands and called Linda and Rose – but the end result is that Catra got to free herself of the meaningless last name that she had been dragging around since childhood.

“You going to share… Grayskull?” Catra asks, bouncing the straw of her drink a bit nervously in her glass. She feels bad for hesitating over the name, but it is going to take awhile to get used to. Catra called Adora by her last name from a young age. Adora would light up when she used it. It all clicked when Adora finally told her how she had been feeling about herself, but she never found a name that really felt right while Catra knew her. They tested out a few, but her last name was their default, as well as something that it was easy for Adora to get others to call her. Pretty much all the kids at the home called her Eternia.

“Right! Um, well, I got adopted pretty quickly. Actually, they fostered me first, but one of my moms, Mara, she’s a social worker. She wasn’t on our case, but she took me in because they were trying to get us all into normal home environments as quickly as they could. It ended up sticking. I changed my full name when they adopted me,” Adora explains, shrugging a little. Adora beams as she talks about it, smiling when she says their names and letting the phrase *my moms* roll off her tongue effortlessly.

Catra doesn’t think she is ever going to be like that, calling Linda and Rose her moms like they always raised her, but it makes sense that Adora would. Catra was always prickly, but Adora wanted a family. She could have adjusted to a home life even after how they had been raised. Catra is glad that she got to have it, at least as much as she could. A small part of her is bitter, but it isn’t really directed at Adora. Catra’s first few years after leaving the group home were rough and she always wondered if it contributed to Linda and Rose’s decision not to adopt her despite how they were otherwise willing to let her be a part of their family.

Eventually, Catra was put in long-term therapy. It helped, but it has been ten years and though she may be scabbed over, she will never be unscarred. Looking at Adora across the table from her, her smile as soft as the day that they were parted and her entire demeanor even

softer, Catra wonders if the problem is just her. Then again, Adora has always been exceptional. Maybe Catra could learn from her. Adora was always her guiding north star, the one who showed her that kindness and love *were* possible even in the darkest of places.

Catra realizes with some horror that though she has always loved the memory of Adora, the real girl behind it hasn't seemed to change that much. Falling in love with this new version of her is going to be as easy as breathing.

Fuck.

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Catra learns that Adora fumbled on picking a major until she ended up with a generic business degree that she didn't care about. She learns that Adora was in a sorority of all things and that she met her one of her best friends during recruitment week, even if they ended up joining different ones in the end. She learns that Adora was one of her sorority's social media managers and that's how she ended up where she is now, failing at the basics of Excel.

"It's not basics! I've used it a lot, but I've never had to use data paths before," Adora defends, but they are both grinning. Catra isn't going to let this go, at least not as teasing material. She always loved ribbing Adora. She is adorable when she gets worked up and she has only gotten cuter – and hotter – in the last few years.

"How have you regularly used Excel without realizing that copying reference formulas makes them refer to their original sheet?" Catra questions, raising an eyebrow at her. She knows that Adora is being genuine, but *come on*. It's kind of hard not to notice, especially if you ever share the sheet with someone else. Adora huffs, slumping in her chair a little. She uses the toothpick that came with her dinner sandwich to stab a stray piece of lettuce and nibbles it off the toothpick like a petulant child. She really hasn't changed.

"I don't usually have to remake and copy entire sheets. I tweet for a living," Adora mumbles. Even Catra knows it's a bit more complicated than that, but she rolls her eyes and lets it go. Their food is all gone at this point and teasing Adora about her Excel skills is something that she can do in the office anyway. They have a lot of ground to cover in topics for *outside* the office that she would rather prioritize at times like now. Unfortunately, Scorpia has already sent her a worried text checking in if everything is alright. It isn't that late, but apparently Catra going out after work is cause for Scorpia to send their secret code text that is supposed to be for if one of them is kidnapped or ends up on a weird date.

"As long as you submit a sheet with data that I can run my macro on, I don't really care what it looks like," Catra tells her as she raises her hand to flag down their waiter. She already told Adora that she didn't have to resubmit, but she does still need *useful* sheets. She catches the waiter's eye, sending him the classic *this date is over, bring me the check* smile before turning back to Adora and seeing her visibly put out. She is pretending not to be – at least,

Catra *thinks* – but her emotions are written all over her face as she glances to the waiter and straightens up in her seat, quickly fixing her slouched dykespreading position so she is sitting up with her knees together, back straight, and hands in her lap.

“If I don’t go home soon, Scorpia is going to think you kidnapped me,” Catra tells her with a raised eyebrow. Adora blinks at her for a moment before relaxing a bit and offering her a hopeful smile. Catra rolls her eyes as the waiter arrives and she tucks her card into the check, immediately handing it back. Adora is so busy… being polite about Catra fleeing – or something, Catra isn’t really sure – that she doesn’t seem to notice that Catra paid until the waiter has already left. She immediately pouts, all attempts to look proper abandoned in favor of sending Catra a kicked puppy look.

“I’m supposed to pay,” she protests. That makes Catra scoff, sending Adora a flat look.

“According to who? This isn’t a date and I guarantee you that accounting pays better than tweeting,” Catra shoots back. Adora seems to glitch for a moment, not reacting at all to Catra’s words for several delayed seconds before she ducks her head a bit sulkily.

“We could have split it,” she mutters. Catra really doesn’t know why she cares.

“Drive me home and we’ll call it even,” Catra offers. Adora instantly lights up like a child being presented with tickets to Disney World. Okay, maybe not *that* much, but the sulking disappears in favor of a bright smile. Adora raises her hand and then freezes it in what Catra swears must be an aborted fist pump.

“Deal! Oh, that was probably too eager, huh? I’ve just… missed you,” Adora replies, sheepishly. Catra’s heart feels like it is thudding in her chest as Adora smiles at her across the table. This could be the innocent happiness of someone meeting an old friend, but Catra’s brain immediately wants to attach more importance to it just because she *wants* Adora to be as eager to reignite past feelings as she is – if Adora even felt something similar for her back then.

Catra rarely gets what she wants. She pushes it down. She is eager to have Adora back in her life, if only to have someone who understands how she ended up where she is. If all they become is just weirdly well-acquainted work friends, then maybe she will at least be able to move on.

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Adora very sheepishly asks for her number as she is driving her home. Catra agrees without hesitation. She definitely doesn’t want to have their likely more emotional futures catchups at work. Her personal life is carefully carved off from her work life except when Scorpia or Entrapta harass her, and she isn’t going to talk about her time in or immediately after the system where anyone who knows her could potentially overhear.

She kind of doesn't want to have those catchups *period*, at least for her end of it, but they are probably going to have to talk about it if Adora is interested in having a deep friendship again. It will probably be healthy for both of them and they'll be able to understand each other in a way that a therapist never could, blah blah, Catra *hates* crying. She hates conversations that she knows are going to make her cry. She certainly isn't having them at work, which means they will have to meet up on their own time, something Catra doesn't want to plan over work email or Slack. Exchanging phone numbers is necessary.

As she types her name into Adora's phone for her, she hesitates for a moment on if she should enter the contact with any kind of nickname. It is normally something that she detests – or at least, she says that she does – but putting herself in under her old last name or something similar might make sense. Staring at her name typed on the screen, however, something occurs to her. She decides to go ahead with *Catra D'Ream*, but she sneaks a glance at Adora in the drivers' seat as she types out her number.

"Catra's not exactly a common name. Did it really never occur to you that you could be emailing me?" Catra asks. She knows that she changed her last name, but so did Adora. It shouldn't have been such a foreign idea to her that Catra could have done the same.

"I, um, never checked what your full name was. It was easier to be rude to an email address. Me and all my friends called it 'the feud with Accounting' so we didn't attach one person to it. They were watching it like it was reality TV," Adora admits, a bit sheepishly. She bites her lip, seeming nervous about Catra's reaction.

"You're what's wrong with the internet," Catra jokes. Adora huffs, but she smiles with a bit of relief. She never minded being the butt of a joke so long as she got it too. People being unattached to online profiles and being able to bully them without conscience *is* a problem, but the fact that Adora is so nice that she needs to pretend she isn't even talking to a person in order to be rude is downright endearing. At least to Catra. She is aware that she has issues though.

"I maintain that you started it. Do you always email like that, or were you having a bad day too?" Adora asks, her tone going from joking to cautious – almost like she expects Catra to be just as prickly about approaching emotions now as she was when they were kids. Catra has definitely made *some* progress – she is pretty sure even the ever-tolerant Scorpia would have gotten sick of her shit by now if she hadn't – but she is still generally opposed to any kind of raw vulnerability. She thinks she showed enough for the day, but she supposes that she could manage some honesty.

"If someone deserves it, I'll fire off – clearly. But Scorpia and her girlfriend were having sex the night before and I have trouble sleeping with mufflers on. I was just grouchy," Catra admits, shrugging. Adora could have easily sent her the wrong sheet on accident since it was so blatantly wrong, but Catra wasn't in the mood to extend anyone the benefit of the doubt that day. She really hates when she has to wear ear mufflers.

The only times that she uses them are when there is no other way for her to avoid hearing Scorpia and Perfuma or when some idiot at work is being too loud for her to focus without help. They are merely noise dampening and not canceling, but that usually works for her. She can still hear her coworkers if they try to talk to her – or annoying blondes burst into her

office – but she can't hear the meeting happening in the conference room two doors down at least.

"They can't go over to her girlfriend's place?" Adora asks, frowning a little as she pulls up to the small brown cottage that Catra shares with the lovebirds. Adora squints at it almost suspiciously, like it has to be wrong, before looking to Catra as if she wouldn't have pointed out that Adora pulling into the wrong driveway by now.

"This *is* her place. The attic is finished and I get the top 'floor' to myself," Catra explains, shrugging. The house is small, but the attic makes it deceptively large, and her set up is actually pretty nice if you ignore the whole *third-wheeling* thing. Given that she only has three people that she would consider her real friends *including* Scorpia and Perfuma, third wheeling is just going to be a fact of her life. She and Scorpia have lived together ever since Catra got placed with the D'Reams. This is a big step up from their shared dorm room in college, at least.

Adora frowns at the building, but she seems to catch Catra's expression out of the corner of her eye because she quickly offers Catra an apologetic smile. Catra really doesn't need anyone judging her living situation. She has plenty of space and privacy, she gets to be with people she likes, and she doesn't even have to drive herself to work, one of her least favorite activities in the world. Commuting is a lot better when she can spend the whole time dicking around on her phone and that is justification enough for her living situation – plus it costs her, like, nothing. She would like to see what *Adora's* investment portfolio looks like.

"Well, if you ever need to get away, I think the only way I'll be able to stop myself from pestering you at work is if we get to hang out. Uh, I mean pester in a non-HR-violating way. I can back off too," Adora offers, seeming to realize what she has said halfway through. It isn't unwanted advances, however, so Catra just snorts as she undoes her seatbelt and reaches for the car door handle.

"We can find time to meet up," Catra assures her, like she isn't also desperate to spend more time together and find out how much of the girl that she misses is still around. Adora beams at her.

"I'll hold you to it," she returns, like she is just as eager as Catra is. Then again, Adora always had the excitability of a puppy. It didn't tend to matter what the subject was, as long as she found it somewhere within the realm of her interests. This will be *interesting* at the very least.

Chapter End Notes

This is actually the very first fic idea I had with a trans Adora, all the way back in November 2020. I've referenced it a number of times on my Tumblr and teased it before, I just never got around to writing it until now.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> I said I wasn't happy with it, so I'm just putting it all out there and wiping my hands of it rather than drawing it out. Hopefully some of y'all enjoy this even if it's messy and not too deep.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The problem with Adora's entire department and everyone she knows being invested in her feud with Accounting is that its sudden absence is immediately noticed. No one noticed Adora's brief trip downstairs during work the day before – after all, she could have just gone to the bathroom – but everyone notices when she doesn't bring up their emails throughout the next day. By midafternoon, her friends have gathered at the "Ideas Table" in the middle of the Marketing department and are somewhat-loudly discussing what they think happened while Adora sits *inches* away and does her best to work and pretend to socialize while also ignoring them.

"I'll bet she couldn't figure out a way to blame them this time and doesn't want to admit defeat," Mermista says while steadily eating the supply of snack fries that Sea Hawk brought her. As far as Adora can tell, the flavored fries are supposed to be her late lunch and possibly Sea Hawk's too. Adora huffs and doesn't respond. She hasn't decided how to handle the Catra situation yet, but what she does know is that absolutely none of her friends can find out that someone who has been so important to her in the past – and hopefully will be just as important in her *future* – works in the same building as them. Next thing she knows, they would be popping down to Accounting to interrogate her.

"We all knew I couldn't be rude for that long," Adora says, not looking up from her laptop. There is a meme going around on Twitter that she thinks it would be really cringey to capitalize on, but it's kind of her job, so she needs to either do it or come up with a good reason for why she didn't in case Marketing gets on her case about it. Despite her job, Adora finds it annoying when brands take part in stuff like this. Now might be a great time to make a normal post actually since people are probably refreshing their feed to keep up.

"She lost," like three different people agree at once. Adora huffs, looking up to shoot her friends a glare before returning to her screen. She didn't, she just can't tell them how much she truly *won*.

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Getting to know Catra again is a weird feeling. On one hand, they can tell a story they were both there for and finish each other's sentences. On the other, Catra is undeniably different. She is softer and quieter, more matured while still having that fire beneath her surface. It seems like she just knows when to hold onto it or release it now. Well, partially at least. Her emails show that she releases it a little more often than Adora would herself, but she always liked Catra's spirit. It is so easy to get sucked in by her again.

Catra always got her and it seems like she still does. There is a shared experience in their years together that builds a connection they have no trouble sparking up before the weekend even arrives. Adora is astounded by how her best friend has managed to stay the same while also maturing. Sure, she's a bit prickly still, but Adora always liked being the one who could break through Catra's tough exterior. Meeting up after work has been nearly daily until she heads down to Accounting on Tuesday and Catra sends her an apologetic look

She informs Adora that she and her sister have plans that night. Adora offers to drive her home anyway, but Catra shakes her head and says that she is riding with her sister.

"We can meet up some other day," Catra promises her as she turns to head down the hall. Adora hopes that by "some other day" she means tomorrow, but if not, maybe they can make do with texting.

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It takes almost two weeks for Adora's friends to notice. They notice the absence of the feud with Accounting, of course, and unanimously declare her the loser, but they don't notice anything *else* going on until Adora and Catra have already worked out that they can meet up after work on Mondays and Thursdays regularly without conflict from either of their schedules. Glimmer notices Adora texting at lunch on a Monday. She leans over to look at Adora's screen and Adora pointedly puts it to sleep, raising her eyebrow at Glimmer's snooping.

"Who are you texting?" Glimmer asks, her voice *barely* casual. Adora sends Bow a look and he puts his arm around Glimmer, pulling her closer to his side and thus away from Adora's phone. Adora offers him a bright smile and unlocks her phone again to text Catra that her friends are getting nosy and she might disappear. "If it wasn't a big deal, why are you trying to hide it?" Glimmer asks, not bothering to pretend she is not a horrible snoop this time.

"What are you, a cop? I'm guilty if I don't violate my privacy for you?" Adora responds. Bow and Glimmer both snort. The truth is that Glimmer is just a gossip and also isn't used to there being secrets between them, but Adora does have *some* boundaries. Ordinarily who she happens to be texting isn't one of them, but she always feels weird about showing others her conversations if only because the person she is talking to might not want her to.

"I met up with an old friend from the foster system like a week ago, is all," Adora tries, shrugging a little. She quickly glances up from her phone, ignoring the series of curse words

that Catra is filling her screen up with just to offend any of Adora's friends who might catch sight of it. Adora is a little nervous about the lie – it *isn't* a lie, but it's not the truth either – but if it shows on her face, Glimmer and Bow both miss it in favor of perking up.

"No *wonder* you stopped caring about Accounting! You have to tell us everything," Glimmer declares, quickly reaching across the table. Adora knows this motion and usually it means Glimmer wants to hold hands – well, hold her hand in a death grip and talk a thousand miles a minute – but her hands are kind of full with her phone at the minute. Luckily, Bow reaches out and catches her hand with his own, intertwining their fingers together instead.

"We got our privacy violated enough back at the home. I'm not giving you details," Adora points out. Telling Glimmer even the name of the person she is talking about gives her intimate detail on their early years since Glimmer knows what the group home was like from Adora. Of course, the fact that it is *Catra* tells her a lot more. Glimmer pouts, but Bow nods.

"Understandable, but I hope we get to the meet them sometime," he says, reasonable when his wife isn't. Adora shrugs even though she hopes the same herself. She would like Catra to become such an integral part of her life again that her best friends couldn't possibly avoid meeting her, but she doesn't know if that will happen any time soon.

"It's really freeing to reconnect, but we'll have to see," she offers diplomatically. In addition to the part of her that has always been embedded in Catra and thus missing since her adoption, Adora has gotten some sense of closure on the years spent at the group home since reuniting with someone else who was there. She thinks she would have gotten that if she had met one of the other kids from the home too, at least as long as they were comfortable with each other, but she is glad it was Catra.

Who is she kidding? She is downright ecstatic it was her.

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The feud with Accounting, it turns out, *isn't* dead. When Adora sends in her next spreadsheet, Catra sends back a scathing review of Adora's Excel skills. She can be a lot more insulting now that they know each other and she is sure that Adora isn't going to report her for workplace harassment. Not that she would have anyway for things like *I've seen better spreadsheets from retirees*, but she certainly would have marched down there if she hadn't already. As it is, Adora rolls her eyes and laughs a little.

That turns out to be her downfall. Frosta looks at her screen and Adora, forgetting her reaction is far from what it used to be, lets her read it. Frosta glances between the most openly insulting message that Adora has gotten so far and the smile on her face and looks extremely skeptical. When Mermista wanders into the office to ask Adora about details for the graphic that she asked her to make, Frosta looks to her and informs her, "Adora is hot for the accountant now." Adora gapes at her as Mermista turns on her with a feral light in her eyes.

“I’m firing you,” Adora declares. She doesn’t think she actually has the power to do that despite Frosta reporting to her, but it only makes the look on Mermista’s face more manic as she advances on Adora. Frosta doesn’t even react.

“You *talked* to them, didn’t you? Is she cute? Did she insult you in person? You were into it, weren’t you?” Mermista asks. Frosta makes a disgusted groaning sound in the background as Adora contemplates the issues with befriending people from your workplace. A mere coworker wouldn’t dare asks those questions, but Mermista doesn’t hesitate. Adora scowls, slumping a little in her seat.

“She asked me to resubmit over a spelling error and I had enough. I went down there and we talked it out. She’s just ribbing me now,” Adora tells her. Despite the insults in Catra’s email, she isn’t asking Adora to resubmit, she just isn’t going to pass up an opportunity to pester her. That part of Catra hasn’t changed one bit over the years. Mermista doesn’t look appeased. In fact, she grins wider.

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Adora would *really* like an invitation to that Slack group right about now. Glimmer and Bow haven’t seemed to put together that Adora’s old friend and the girl in Accounting everyone is now convinced that she has a crush on could be related, but all her friends watch the “feud” with even more interest than they showed while they were bickering. Frosta is a little snitch. Adora is no longer self-reporting on when Catra emails her, but apparently her face gives it away and inevitably someone shows up to extract the story from her – that is, if all her friends don’t manage to show up at once.

On Catra’s end, apparently the other accountants she leads are respectful of the fact that she and Adora talked it out and their “rivalry” is more friendly now. No one is trying to read her messages over her shoulder. She got off easy. Her foster sister apparently works in HR – she is new, Catra helped her apply to the job just last year – and she is one of only two other people to know the full situation between Adora and Catra. Apparently anything that you tell Scorpia her girlfriend learns too, but she doesn’t work here, so Adora doesn’t care.

She would gladly tell Glimmer and Bow if she didn’t know for a fact that Glimmer would start showing up mysteriously on the second floor, especially considering that Adora is now taking some of her lunches down there with Catra when none of her friends are available to notice. It is easiest on days when Glimmer walks over to the neighboring building where Bow works to have lunch with him instead. Adora really likes having lunch with her friends, but lunches with Catra feel special.

Glimmer and Bow are the closest that Adora has ever come to having a friend like Catra, but it isn’t the same. At the end of the day, they are *just* friends. Best friends, but not *friend* friends the way that she and Catra were – and seemingly still are. They have an easy comradery, laughing and joking even after all these years. Catra’s laugh is just as cute as it always was, as is her sneeze, and her yawn, and alright, Adora might just think *everything*

about her is cute. It was a real kicker when she realized that she was in love with Catra in the middle of one of her high school therapy sessions.

She tried to move on, but it never really worked. She went on a few dates, but eventually she decided that she needs to have a deep bond with someone like she once had with Catra before they could start to compare as a potential partner. It was an excuse to focus on her friends and give up on romantic pursuits, but it worked for her no matter what Glimmer thinks of it. That enforced celibacy is likely why everyone is so eager to keep an eye on the Accounting saga despite Adora's multiple protests that it isn't like that.

Honestly, she is surprised that no one has tried to come down and scope Catra out, but maybe they have and they were just subtle enough about it that Catra didn't notice. She wears the ear mufflers sometimes after all and Adora's friends certainly wouldn't tell *her* if they had investigated who it was. They would blow up the Slack chat with the information instead. It wouldn't be the end of the world if they identified Catra, but Adora likes their little secret relationship that isn't actually a "relationship." At least, not really. She doesn't know anymore.

Catra's eyes sparkle sometimes and she often runs her eyes over Adora's body or face. At first it made perfect sense – Adora had changed a *lot* and it would take awhile to take in – but it is harder to dismiss the longer it goes on, or when Catra casually places a hand on her arm to get her attention and seemingly squeezes her bicep for no reason. It's little things, like the way Catra's tail twitched when she asked Adora if she had a girlfriend, and the way she sometimes shuts down a little and scoots away from Adora whenever a coworker walks in on them in the breakroom.

If they're acting too close for coworkers, where does that leave them? Adora isn't sure. She could be letting wishful thinking rule her – or she could be right.

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"Big news," Mermista declares gleefully as she flings herself down in an empty chair at the Ideas Table. Adora sighs, looking up from her laptop.

"If it isn't related to the campaign, I don't want to hear it," she informs her. Adora and Glimmer are in the *middle* of something here. Adora glances over at the notes that Frosta is taking for them and finds that she is writing down Mermista's appearance at the table in the style of a Shakespeare entrance. Adora is trying to get this meeting done before five so she can meet up with Catra on time and stuff like this doesn't help her get things done.

"Noted and ignored. Hey, Glimmer: there's a magicat in Accounting," Mermista says, immediately turning away from Adora to grin at Glimmer. Adora feels her heart skip as Glimmer's eyes go tellingly wide. Unfortunately, all of Adora's – and Glimmer's – female friends know about Adora's *track record*. It came out at Glimmer's bachelorette party that Adora has only ever slept with two people, both of them magicats. Adora swears that she

doesn't have a thing for them, that would be weird and creepy, she just kind of has a thing for *Catra* that she was trying to get over before giving up.

Glimmer, however, doesn't know all that because Adora was a little emotionally repressed in college and definitely didn't want to lay her feelings bare in front of a group of drunk girls – she had promised Bow she would look over Glimmer and was one of the few sober people present – so she turns to Adora with the same feral light in her eyes that Mermista has. To Adora's right, Frosta lets out a groaning sigh. She may find getting to harass her "boss" fun, but she seems to be getting sick of Adora's love life as a topic. Adora is pretty sure that Frosta only puts things in Slack at this point so Adora will be busy dealing with her friends' reactions and she won't give her any work for a bit.

"Do you realize how bad it sounds when you say it like that? She's just an old friend," Adora responds. They are in the middle of the room after all and she doesn't want the entire marketing department thinking she is weirdly into magicats. Glimmer's eyes go from narrowed to wide as Adora says that, apparently finally putting together Adora's reacquaintance with the accountant.

"Wait, is she-" she starts to ask, but Adora cuts her off quickly.

"Yes, it's Catra. And leave her alone. She's just trying to do her *job*," Adora says. The name *Catra* won't mean anything to Mermista, but Glimmer knows that Catra was Adora's best friend back in the group home. She was three hundred times that too, but whatever. Mermista's eyebrows shoot up to her hairline as she glances between a gaping Glimmer and Adora shifting a bit uncomfortably. She really doesn't want anyone getting nosy with her and Catra. There is a fragile hope to their interactions now and she doesn't want it shattered by intruders. Unfortunately, though Glimmer's gaze makes it clear that she *understands*, it doesn't make her back off like Adora – rather unrealistically – hoped. Instead, she pulls out her phone and immediately calls Bow.

"We have a lesbian situation," Glimmer says as Adora sighs and drops her head onto the table.

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Adora is fifteen minutes late. When she walks up to Catra, she sends her a strained smile and immediately grabs her arm, continuing to walk forward without stopping.

"We're getting on the elevator and not letting anyone else on," Adora says despite the fact that neither of them ever take it. Catra, predictably, glances over her shoulder. She can't see the faces pressed up against the stairwell window from this angle which, more importantly, means that they can't see her. When they reach the elevator, Adora impatiently pushes the call button before any of her friends decide to stick their heads out and spy. Catra raises a brow at her.

“I could talk to Scorpia. She could intervene on ‘HR’s behalf’ without actually making a report,” Catra tells her. Adora texted her when it became clear that the inquisition – which had moved to her office at that point – was going to make her late. It went on for long enough that some of her friends who still have work to do will have to stay late now. It serves them right. Adora sighs and shakes her head as the elevator arrives and they hurry onto it.

“No, they won’t *actually* harass us. They’ll just be annoying to me,” Adora tells her as she hits the lobby button. “They’ll be calmer tomorrow – *I hope* – but I’ve been single for a long time and-” Adora pulls herself to a dead halt, her eyes going wide as she stares directly across from her at the blinking down arrow on the elevator’s display. Why did she just say that? She can feel Catra’s arm tensing where she still has her hand around her wrist.

Fuck. Fuck, fuck, fuck.

“They just got the wrong idea,” she mutters as they reach the floor of the lobby. The air is silent except for the elevator arrival ding. Adora isn’t looking away from the panel. Awkwardly, Catra clears her throat beside Adora and then twists her wrist in her grip. Adora lets it go, wincing a little. She is surprised when Catra grabs her back, taking hold of her hand this time and striding forward with purpose. Adora lets herself be led forward out the elevator doors. The lobby is bright compared to the elevator and she finds herself squinting as Catra leads her out into the parking lot and then hesitates.

“Your car?” she prompts. Adora swallows. Good and bad – Catra is willing to be in an enclosed space with her, but she also wants them to be in private for this conversation. Adora dutifully nods, walking forward to lead Catra to where she parked it. She managed to avoid needing to use the parking garage today. She is grateful the walk is short, even if it is the last time that they will likely be hand-in-hand. This is painful. When they get to the car, Adora hurriedly unlocks it and they sit heavily in their seats. Adora stares straight ahead, afraid.

“What *exactly* gave them ‘the wrong idea?’” Catra asks from the passenger seat. Adora can hear the air quotes in her voice. She winces a little. She doesn’t know what to say. Technically *nothing* did because Adora is actually head over heels for Catra. When it comes to how they picked up on it, Mermista was already assuming that Adora was hot for the accountant. Add that to the fact that Glimmer knew Adora had a deep admiration for her best friend, it wasn’t hard to figure out that how Adora has a crush – to put it mildly.

“They were trying to convince me to ask you out,” Adora admits, still looking at the steering wheel. That isn’t a lie, but it doesn’t directly incriminate her. It just means that her *friends* found out about her old friend and told her to take a shot at it. Cautiously, Adora peeks over to the passenger seat, unable to just quietly wait for Catra to deliver the killing blow. Catra is watching her with wide eyes, her gaze flicking over Adora’s face and intermittently holding eyecontact.

“You’re *so* lucky you’re cute. You’re such a dumbass otherwise,” Catra finally says. Adora blinks at Catra. She feels her heart fluttering in her throat, unsure of what that means. Her reaction makes Catra roll her eyes, though she doesn’t seem that confident for herself, so Adora doesn’t know why she is bothering to put on a front. “Just say it like a normal person, Adora,” Catra elaborates.

Oh. That's. *Oh*. Good. Good? Great? Good. Definitely. Right? Adora isn't sure. Either Catra is telling Adora to ask her out or she is telling her to just be upfront about what happened so that she can reject her. At this point, Adora just has to take her chance. It isn't like Catra doesn't know by now anyway.

"I had feelings for you when we were kids and they're definitely back now because you're still *amazing* so my friends want me to ask you out but I don't want to ruin our chance at getting our friendship back," Adora rushes out, wincing before she even finishes saying it. Catra, for her part, blinks widely at Adora. Adora feels like her heart is beating in her throat as she waits for the reaction, good or bad.

After several long seconds of silence, Catra begins purring. It shocks Adora, but it seems to surprise Catra a little too judging by her flicking tail. After a moment, she turns away from Adora and faces forward, reaching for her seatbelt with a smug smile spreading on her face. She is *still purring*. Adora hasn't heard that sound in years.

"We're going to that restaurant again," Catra declares. Adora swears her heartrate spikes. After a hesitant moment, she reaches forward and properly turns on Swift Wind. As the car rumbles to life, she swallows and glances at Catra out of the corner of her eye.

"And then?" she asks, because she *thinks* that Catra just asked her on a date, but she would really like some kind of solid confirmation. Catra smirks, sending Adora a glance that would be condescending if it didn't make her cheeks flush.

"And then you can pay for dinner," she assures. It takes Adora a second to remember Catra's words on that first day – *this isn't a date* – but when she does, she lights up, eagerly nodding as she releases her parking brake. She doesn't know if she has ever been so eager to spend money in her life.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact, this is my oldest fic idea ever as far as the gap between idea and writing goes. The second oldest was WDtFD at 1 year, but it has been 1 year and 2 months since I had this idea back in November of 2020. I still have one fic idea left from 2020, but it's from December, so we'll see if I manage to write it in the next month or if it sets a new record lol.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!